Spotlight: News On Air

Discussion on the Fifth Edition of the Kautilya Economic Conclave

Total Words Count: 1,385 words

Chapter 1: Introduction to the Enclave

Akashvani: This is Akashvani. In the program Spotlight, now we bring you a discussion on the fifth edition of the Kautilya Economic Conclave. The participants are Shubhoy Bhachari, economic analyst, and Nishit Kumar, anchor. The fifth Kautilya Economic Conclave, that is KEC 2026, is scheduled to be held from the 3rd to the 5th of October 2026 at New Delhi under the theme **resilience** in an age of flux. The 3-day gathering will bring together senior policymakers, economists, academics, financial experts, and international thought leaders.

Since its **inception** in 2022, the Kautilya Economic Conclave has grown into a forum for dialogue on economic and policy challenges. Early editions were held under the themes redefining the future, navigating a world on fire, the Indian era, and seeking prosperity in **turbulent** times. And to discuss more about it, we are privileged to have been joined in by noted economic analyst Shubhoy Bhachari.

Nishit Kumar: Mr. Bhachari, welcome to the show.

Shubhoy Bhachari: Happy to be here.

Chapter 2: India's Global Positioning

Nishit Kumar: So Bhachari Ji, as we see that this is the fifth edition of this Kautilya Economic Conclave being held, and as the tagline itself says that we are at the crossroads of economic challenges. Now if we look at managing geoeconomic **vulnerabilities** in the present time—so geography and trade choke points increasingly weaponized—where do you see India emerging in between all the chaos and all the crossfires that's going on?

Shubhoy Bhachari: First word I would want to say is that India is not—I should say not an emerging economy anymore. S&P report on India, which was released just a few days ago, and the most **authoritative** report says that India is already positioned as a leading power in Asia. Now that means that the relationships, the positioning, and all the things that happen regarding India are of global **significance**.

In that sort of a situation, what we are looking at is what are the advantages that happen with India and also what are the disadvantages which India will have to take on as part of the global, very fluid economic order. The Kautilya Economic Conclave is run in the Institute of Economic Growth in Delhi University, and it is a very good place to take stock of emerging issues. It gives countries like India its very own crafted economic platform where policymakers and business leaders come together to understand which way the global economy would be moving.

Chapter 3: Navigating Global Uncertainty

Nishit Kumar: Right, so Mr. Bhachari Ji, as we understand the theme says we are at the crossroad, the flux point or inflection point. How should India and its peers navigate the shift from **multilateralism** to maybe bilateral friend-shoring without getting that much locked into restrictive geopolitical blocks? We have seen India reaching out to the European Union, Australia, and New Zealand. Of course, the India-US trade deal remains an Achilles heel as of now, but how do you see this?

Shubhoy Bhachari: Well, this is the sort of world where you should be friends with everybody but look at only your own interests. The uncertainty in the world economy has not only not **dissipated**, it has rather become even more intense. Given that intensity, it's very important for India to look at nobody as without a friend but be very **cognizant** of what we need. When we are looking at building our semiconductor capacity or solar panel manufacturing, other countries will challenge us.

Even developing data centers, they are continuously making India their home. That means India has a very strong electricity grid, a good source of water supply, and a hugely sophisticated labor force. Growth has become very uneven in this world. We have lived through a tariff war, restrictions on the movement of skilled labor, and we could very soon see restrictions on the movement of capital. India is navigating with caution and ensuring that its own interests are not **jeopardized**.

For example, the Reserve Bank of India was recently concerned about foreign exchange reserves, so it offered a very attractive deposit scheme which was a resounding success. $127 billion flowed in. Whenever the situation is **opportune**, Indian policymakers will take steps to ensure that interests are vitally protected. We go around looking for good prices at which oil can be bought. That creates soft inflationary conditions for India. These dynamic policy changes are necessary in the current very **volatile** world economy.

Chapter 4: Democracy and Inclusion

Nishit Kumar: Right. Earlier today, Vice President Mr. C.P. Radhakrishnan delivered the inaugural address, stating that economic **resilience** cannot be separated from social resilience, and inclusion is the foundation of resilience in an age of flux. He said true resilience lies in ensuring no citizen or region is left behind.

Shubhoy Bhachari: These statements are very significant, especially the fact that democracy and governance are linked. The new generation of citizens wants to know *how* a country is getting prosperous. India looks for prosperity from an **inclusive** perspective—where everybody gets a chance to expand their life chances, increase educational qualifications, get good health cover, and live in a less polluted environment.

Shubhoy Bhachari (Cont'd): The fact that India is a multi-party democracy works extremely to the benefit of the nation. It actually **bolsters** the image of India as a good investment destination where good capital would want to come.

Chapter 5: Digital Public Infrastructure

Nishit Kumar: Earlier we talked about data centers and artificial intelligence. How can the foundational layers of DPI—identity, digital payments, open data networks—evolve to build a secure dataset for AI models?

Shubhoy Bhachari: It's not just the digital public health model, but digital food and agro-processing models that are coming up rapidly. Major investments ensure that you **harness** the powers of the AI setup to create a better supply of food and ensure health infrastructure is made inclusive and effective. In India, there is a very major feeling that AI is a very useful technology to move ahead on the technological front.

Chapter 6: Demographics and Development

Nishit Kumar: There has been talk for a long time on the **demographic** dividend. What can really be done to address regional demographic divergences, balancing aging workforces with the youth, so we can actually build that dream of Viksit Bharat by 2047?

Shubhoy Bhachari: A lot is already happening. For instance, the ease of travel across India is a major change. People aren't hamstrung by the absence of opportunities to travel outside their cities. Balancing the demand-supply gap will require providing affordable housing to migrants coming into cities, and simultaneously ensuring that within the city, transport and water supply become much more **robust**.

Recently, the Union government approved a huge budget to improve the traffic network in Delhi. Wasting time in the flow of traffic is a major **dampener** for productivity, so this investment can give us returns very fast. People can spend longer hours on their work instead of being locked in transport. Substantial changes are being made in how goods and people travel.

Nishit Kumar: Thank you so very much, Mr. Bhachari, for having joined us and sharing your views.

Akashvani: You were listening to a discussion on the fifth edition of the Kautilya Economic Conclave. The participants were Shubhoy Bhachari, economic analyst, and Nishit Kumar, anchor. This program was produced and presented by the News Services Division of Akashvani.

Vocabulary Guide Available

A fully alphabetized vocabulary table detailing all the highlighted CEFR B1, B2, C1, and C2 words—including serial numbers, English meanings, Hindi translations, and example sentences—is provided in the accompanying Vocabulary Document.